

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Vladimir Putin said that he believed that Russia’s war with Ukraine was “coming to an end”. Speaking after a scaled-back Victory Day parade, Russia’s president said he was willing to discuss security arrangements for Europe, touting Gerhard Schröder as an intermediary. The former chancellor of Germany has become something of [a lobbyist](#) for Mr Putin. Russian sentiment appears to be [turning against](#) Mr Putin.

Saudi Aramco, the world’s biggest oil company, said its profits rose to \$33.6bn in the first quarter of 2026, up 26% year on year. The firm has been pumping as much as 7m barrels of oil per day through its east-west pipeline, allowing it to export via Saudi Arabia’s west coast, even as war has gummed up flows going through the Strait of Hormuz.

Lebanon’s health ministry said that Israeli strikes killed 39 people on Saturday. Israel said it was targeting militants from [Hizbullah](#), an Iran-backed militia, but was “aware” of reports of civilian casualties. Fighting has continued despite [a fragile ceasefire](#); **America** is set to host another round of talks between the two countries on Thursday.

Catherine West, a backbench MP, said she would challenge **Sir Keir Starmer** for the leadership of Britain's Labour Party on Monday, if no member of the prime minister's cabinet puts themselves forward. Sir Keir has stumbled from crisis to crisis since his party won a huge majority in 2024, culminating in a humiliating performance in [local elections](#) on Thursday. He has consistently rejected calls to step down.

Australia's anti-immigration **One Nation** party won its first lower-house seat in a by-election in Farrer, New South Wales. Its candidate, David Farley, received a projected 60% of the primary vote. In January the populist-right outfit [pushed ahead](#) of Australia's centre-right opposition coalition in national polls.

Peter Magyar took office as **Hungary's prime minister**, bringing to an end Viktor Orbán's decade and a half in power. The [new government](#) promises to undo many of Mr Orbán's authoritarian policies. "I will not rule over Hungary, I will serve my country," said Mr Magyar. He called on Tamas Sulyok, Hungary's president, to resign for having failed to stand up to Mr Orbán.

MV Hondius, the cruise ship struck by an outbreak of **hantavirus**, arrived in the **Canary Islands**. Six cases of the disease have so far been confirmed on board; three passengers have died. Doctors and aircraft were waiting to evacuate the 147 people remaining on the ship. Symptoms can take up to eight weeks to appear, meaning they face a long period of isolation.

Word of the week: mirror life, synthetic organisms built from mirror-image versions of natural molecules, which could potentially enable a new [era of bioterrorism](#).



Photograph: EPA

In London, a march against antisemitism

On Sunday Jewish groups will march through central London to demand that more is done to tackle [antisemitism](#). The march follows a series of antisemitic attacks in Britain, most recently the stabbing of two men in Golders Green, a north London suburb, on April 29th. (Another man was attacked on the same day in a different location.) Sir Keir Starmer, the prime minister, announced a spate of reforms in response, including an extra £25m (\$34m) for security in Jewish areas and legislation that would allow the government to better fight state-sponsored terror.

The march also has a more tacit purpose. Sir Keir and some Jewish groups have suggested that near-weekly protests in London against Israel's war in Gaza may have stirred up antisemitism—which organisers of those protests vehemently deny. Sunday's march is designed to show that opponents of antisemitism can show up in large numbers, too.



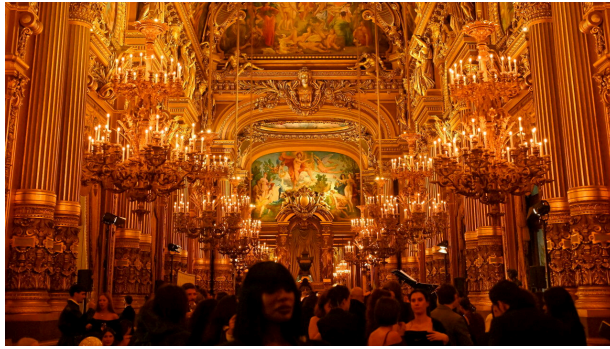
Photograph: Getty Images

Mother's Day, the urban way

American families celebrate Mother's Day on Sunday. [Fewer will do so in cities](#). Across Chicago, between 2010 and 2024, the population aged under 18 declined by 22%, according to census bureau data. In Los Angeles the figure was 23%; in New York, 12%. But in the country's richest, densest cities, there is one group defying the trend: wealthier white families.

In Chicago the population of non-Hispanic white children grew by 6% from 2010 to 2024, faster than the white population overall. In Washington, DC, it rose by an astonishing 62%. Race is not a perfect proxy for income. But the frequent sightings of Uppababy prams (\$899 plus tax) and infants in Patagonia coats (\$99 plus tax) on the cities' streets suggest these are wealthy families.

Such parents are skipping the suburbs once they have children—partly because they are doing so later in life, and so are more likely to be able to afford to stay. In that respect, city parenting has become a financial flex.



Photograph: Getty Images

Can opera serenade a new generation?

This weekend France hosts its 19th *Tous à l'Opéra* (“everyone to the opera”), an annual jamboree that sees several prestigious Parisian and Île-de-France houses open their doors free of charge. The theme of this year’s edition is “youth”. But [are young people going to the opera?](#) In March Timothée Chalamet, an influential young actor, was widely criticised for saying that “no one cares” about the art form anymore.

Alex Beard, boss of London’s Royal Ballet and Opera thinks that is *buffa* (farce). He noted that more 20- to 30-year-olds attend his theatre than any other age group—and claimed that Mr Chalamet’s comments boosted ticket sales. That chimes with a study by Opera America in 2025, which found that the number of first-time audience members had risen steadily since 2020. Nearly a third of new spectators were aged between 18 and 34. Initiatives like *Tous à l'Opéra* may prompt even more to join the chorus.



Photograph: Getty Images

Sinner takes all

Last year Jannik Sinner won two of tennis's four grand slams, [the sport's](#) most prestigious tournaments. In 2026 the Italian has gone up a gear, winning more matches, sets and games than a year ago, as well as thumping more aces. Last week he brushed aside Alexander Zverev, the world number three, in the final of the Madrid Open. Mr Sinner lost just three games in a 56-minute demolition, extending his winning streak to 23 matches.

This weekend he is playing in the Rome Masters, where bookies give him a 66% chance of winning. That is because Carlos Alcaraz, the world number two and the only man capable of stopping him, is out with a wrist injury. Between them, the pair have won the last nine grand slams. With no return date yet set for Mr Alcaraz, expect Mr Sinner's dominant year to continue.



Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Vijay, the action hero who conquered India's economic powerhouse

“A lion only comes out to hunt; it never comes out to just look around,” thundered Vijay. The mononymous south Indian movie star has issued countless such warnings to his foes (before duly dispatching them) over the course of 76 [Tamil films](#). This threat, however, was delivered not on screen, but at a political rally in Tamil Nadu, where he was campaigning for state elections.

The theatrical language worked. On May 4th Vijay's party, Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), won the state's vote, toppling a 59-year duopoly of regional parties. On Sunday the 51-year-old was sworn in as chief minister. That is hugely consequential. Tamil Nadu is India's fastest-growing economy, home to 78m people as well as Apple factories and much of the country's automotive industry.

Tamil Nadu's movie industry has long been a screen test for local politicians: nearly every chief minister over the past six decades has been connected to it. Vijay, though, was raised inside it. At just ten years old his father, a director, cast him in his first film. His later all-action roles turned him into what Tamils call a “mass hero” (ie, beloved by the masses). Anointed “the commander” by his fans, on screen he foiled terrorists, battled land-grabbing tycoons

and exposed electoral fraud on screen. In one film he wrestled a hyena with his bare hands to a pulsating soundtrack.

Vijay's legions of devoted fans came to believe he could be the real-life hero he played. His acolytes organised themselves in loud and energetic fan clubs, which make ideal political vehicles. Turning them towards TVK required mere consolidation and rebranding.

TVK claims to stand for social justice, egalitarianism and Tamil pride. Vijay, a Catholic, has called the Hindu-nationalist Bharatiya Janata Party, which runs India, his "ideological opponent", and lambasted its treatment of minorities. He dismissed Tamil Nadu's previous rulers as corrupt and dynastic. These allegations resonated with voters—especially youngsters.

TVK has promised to fulfil its ideology through an assortment of welfare schemes. But how a party of novices does this is unclear. And it will have to govern in a coalition while contending with the two influential parties he dispatched to the opposition. Ahead of Vijay's swearing-in ceremony, rumours swirled that the bitter rivals might even ally to unseat him. In the jungle of politics, every beast is hunting the lion.

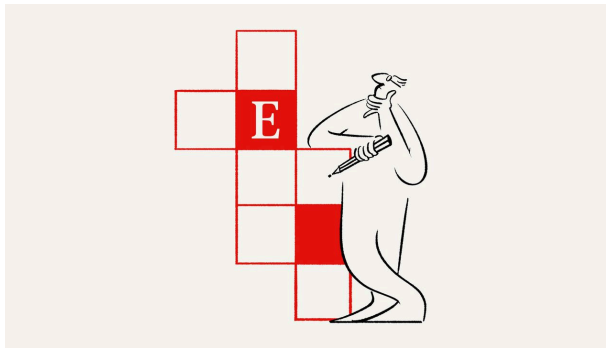


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Wired and beaten one-nil (6)

2 across - Gamble on border (5)

3 across - Shout in pain, colourfully? (6)

1 down - Watching The Birds trilogy? Oh no! Horrific! (11)

Straight clues

1 across - Connected to the internet (6)

2 across - Shrubbery used as boundary (5)

3 across - Sunny hue; song by Coldplay (6)

1 down - The study of avian anatomy, behaviour, etc (11)



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Elena Zăvoianu in Leuven, Belgium

Emilio Ferreira in Buenos Aires, Argentina

Lee Brownfield in El Paso, Texas

They gave the correct answers of Pink Floyd, Creedence Clearwater Revival, The Police, R.E.M and Andy Williams. The theme is that they had hit songs or albums about the moon: The Dark Side of the Moon, Bad Moon Rising, Walking on the Moon, Man on the Moon and Moon River.

The questions were:

Monday: Which prog rock group was founded by Syd Barrett, Nick Mason, Roger Waters and Richard Wright?

Tuesday: John Fogerty was the main songwriter of which rock group?

Wednesday: Andy Summers was the guitarist of which British rock band?

Thursday: Michael Stipe is the lead singer of which band from Athens, Georgia?

Friday: Which easy-listening singer had a long-running TV show in the 1960s and later established his own theatre in Branson, Missouri?

Life is a long lesson in humility.

J. M. Barrie